Writing About Literature, Art, and Culture

Women in Science Fiction

76-106 / FALL 2023 / FIRST MINI

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Office hours: By appointment via Zoom

Course materials on Canvas
Zoom: https://cmu.zoom.us/j/8564286385



Speculative landscape, digitally generated course illustration, 2026 (provisional artwork).

Course Description

This section of Writing About Literature and Culture introduces close reading and analytical writing through works of speculative fiction by women. Readings consider questions of authorship, imagined worlds, gender, embodiment, and power across early modern and modern literary traditions. Students practice interpreting literary texts through theoretical lenses and composing thesis-driven essays.

Writing About Literature and Culture

All required readings are available on Canvas.

Learning Objectives

At Carnegie Mellon, we hope our students will be able to understand their environments, assess rhetorical needs, and use their knowledge and resources to craft documents that connect with readers. After taking 76-106, you should be able to write interpretive essays that are compelling, careful, clear, and considerate of your readers. you should be able to:

- Use close reading strategies for reading literary texts
- Read with a theoretical lens or framework to interpret a text
- Interpret complex texts to frame and respond to significant questions
- Write clear, reader-centered, reasonable arguments
- Employ rhetorical strategies for writing interpretive, thesis-driven academic essays
- Integrate textual evidence strategically to advance your own essay's argument
- Analyze model texts to understand the demands of a writing task
- Develop strategies for managing your writing processes
- Engage in peer collaboration for all stages of writing, including planning, drafting, and revising

Assignments

The syllabus and calendar are subject to change based on class needs. I will go over changes in class and/or via an announcement on Canvas. Please adjust your settings so announcements are sent directly to your email address. All assignments due on a given date will be in a module labeled with that date.

The higher stakes writing tasks in this course are the close reading analysis and the theoretical lens argument essays. In order to write these papers, we will employ a method called "comparative genre analysis"—in other words, we will examine samples of writing to notice features that you might want to use. Other kinds of writing you'll produce include lower stakes, minor writing assignments (called "metacognitive reflections"), in-process outlines and notes for yourself, and reviews of your peers' writing.

Close Reading Analysis	25%
Theoretical Lens Analysis	45%
Minor Writing Assignments	20%
Attendance and Participation	10%

The CMU Student Senate voted to do away with pluses and minuses in final grades. I round up from the point-five (i.e., an 89.5 and above is an A). Please understand that I have to be consistent to be fair.

Grading Standards: A (90-100) B (80-89) C (70-79) D (60-69) R (below 60)

Course Overview and Policies

As you may or may not know from the university's first-year writing course descriptions document, you have enrolled in a half-semester course called a "mini." This mini is worth 4.5 units, which means that it is half of a 9-unit course. The number of hours you should expect to work in this course is 9 hours per week—3 of those hours will be used for class time.

This course aims toward helping you build skills for noticing and writing about features of artistic and literary texts. Unlike the two other minis offered by first-year writing, this course focuses upon the academic writing situation usually associated with humanities and the arts. We focus on the academic communication genre referred to as the interpretive analytical essay form, usually known as a thesis-driven essay that emerges from sources. The other two mini courses focus on different communication genres and use different organizational patterns, including problem/solution/feasibility in public problems and IMRD in writing about data.

Class Participation and Note-taking

You must do the assigned homework and come prepared to participate in class. You are expected to:

- Contribute to general class discussions,
- Contribute to small group discussions,
- Seek feedback from other class members on work in progress, and
- Provide thoughtful feedback to other class members on their work.

Being prepared for this class includes:

- Paying close attention to the assignments for each class,
- Doing the homework, and
- Bringing relevant materials with you to class.

Deadlines

All written assignments must be submitted before the deadline. Please bear in mind the following policies regarding lateness:

- **Rough Drafts:** Rough drafts for the major assignments will not be accepted late. Peer review is a time-sensitive process, and by submitting a draft late you interfere with your classmates' progress.
- **Graded Drafts: For every day that a final draft is late, you will lose a full letter grade for that paper.** However, final drafts of the contribution paper (the third assignment) **will not be accepted late.** Extensions may be granted under extraordinary circumstances at my discretion, but only if you contact me prior to the final deadline.
- **Homework assignments:** We will often draw on or discuss homework assignments in class; for this reason, I expect homework to be submitted on time. you are still responsible for completing and submitting the day's homework if you do not attend class.

**Failing to attach a file to Canvas correctly (so that I can't access or view it) can result in your losing credit for an assignment. It's your responsibility to make sure that your assignments have been submitted successfully. If you are concerned about a Canvas submission, you can always email it to me as a "safety net."

General Guidelines on Submitting Assignments

- Please note that to receive a passing grade, you must hand in the major papers.
- Assignments must be submitted in electronic form, as word .doc or .docx files, pdfs, or as canvas posts. check assignment guidelines for specifics.
- Carefully edit and proofread all texts to control problems in grammar, spelling, and punctuation.
- Any time you cite an essay, film, or book in an assignment, include a works cited section of your essay that provides complete and accurate bibliographic information.

Attendance and Lateness

Since this is a small discussion class, attendance is mandatory. The reason this class has an attendance policy is so that we practice what we preach—that academic texts are built in collaboration with other readers and writers and not in isolation, and that academic authors are responsible to a community of knowledge makers. In this class and in our professional lives, we make knowledge that is valuable to a community through talk, interaction, and connection.

Arrive on time. You won't get an A in this class if you can't get here on time. Lateness not only disrupts the class but also shows a good deal of disrespect for your peers and for your instructor. For every three days you are late to class, you will be marked for one absence. If you are more than 15 minutes late to class, you will be marked absent for that day. Sleeping in class can result in being marked absent.

You are allotted two absences in this class without penalty—once you miss that third class, your grade in the class will begin to drop. Treat this attendance policy like a "personal" or "sick day" policy you might find in a workplace. In other words, these absences usually occur because of minor illnesses or schedule conflicts (e.g., a delayed Monday morning flight after a weekend holiday).

Plan ahead if you think you might miss class for religious holidays or for other scheduled events. You need to plan your semester carefully so that you do not use all of your personal/sick days at once.

In the case of university-sanctioned activities (e.g., athletics or a course-specific trip that takes you out of town), you ***must provide documentation*** for these absences so that they do not count against your final grade.

If you have extenuating circumstances that could affect your attendance throughout the semester (such as illness, athletics, or a family emergency), it is your responsibility to notify me about your situation and to get some sort of authoritative documentation to excuse your absences. This kind of documentation should originate from the Dean's office, typically, because in these circumstances a student's academic advising team is coordinating communication with all of your faculty. Notes from family doctors are insufficient for documenting extenuating circumstances.

If you miss a class meeting, you are responsible to contact your peers for materials and information you've missed. Missing a class is no excuse for not completing the homework. Likewise, I expect you to have read the assigned readings and to be ready to discuss them, even if you were absent the class before. All of our reading is immediately relevant to the course's assignments, so consider your readings just as important as any written homework you have. I can call on people in class discussion, and it's embarrassing (for you and for me) to have to announce to the class that you haven't done the reading.

Using Sources Properly and Academic Integrity
At Carnegie Mellon, we believe in the excellence of our students and in the integrity of our academic programs. We also believe that your good ideas become better when you test them against the ideas of others. At the same time, we believe that acknowledging this kind of collaboration with others is an important aspect of membership in an academic community. In this course, the following kinds of collaboration and assistance are permitted: a) in-class collaboration such as group work, pair work, class discussion, and peer review; b) discussing your ideas regarding the three major assignments with other students; c) graded peer reviews; d) assistance provided by the student academic success center (https://www.cmu.edu/student-success/).

Any collaboration or assistance of these types should be acknowledged in writing; we will discuss how to incorporate such acknowledgments in your writing in this course. Also within this course, it is imperative that you discuss with me when it is appropriate to use your writing from a completed assignment (from either this class or from another one) within a new writing task. University policy is clear that students cannot use text from a graded assignment from one course for another assignment in another course without discussing your decision making with your instructors.

Anyone who uses non-documented material from another source, including work by other students as well as online sources (including unauthorized assistance from AI tools like Chat GPT), could receive a failing grade for the entire course and could be referred to the dean's office for further disciplinary action.

Incomplete Grades
University policy states the following about incomplete grades:
"Carnegie Mellon students are expected to complete a course during the academic semester in which the course was taken. However, if the instructor agrees, a grade of 'I' (incomplete) may be given when a student, for reasons beyond his or her control, has been unable to complete the work of a course, but the work completed to date is of passing quality and the grade of incomplete provides no undue advantage to that student over other students.

In awarding an 'I' grade, an instructor must specify the requirements for completing the work and designate a default letter grade where no further work is submitted. Students must complete the required course work no later than the end of the following academic semester, or sooner if required by prior agreement. the instructor must record the permanent grade by the last day of the examination period of that following semester, or enrollment services will administratively assign the default grade." (via https://www.cmu.edu/policies/student-and-student-life/grading.html)

A student requesting a grade of "I" in a department of English course must meet the above conditions, including having completed a sufficient amount of course work (at least 50%, ideally 70%). The student should be completing the same work that everyone else in the course will complete. There must be a written contract, available from the instructor, that shows agreement about what work needs to be completed, the deadline by which the work should be submitted, and what the default grade will be should the work not be submitted by the deadline. Cases in which a graduating student requests an "i" grade must be discussed by the instructor and the department head.

Accommodations for Students with Disabilities

If you have a disability and have an accommodations letter from the Disability Resources office, I encourage you to discuss your accommodations and needs with me as early in the semester as possible. I will work with you to ensure that accommodations are provided as appropriate. If you suspect that you may have a disability and would benefit from accommodations but are not yet registered with the Office of Disability Resources, I encourage you to contact them at access@andrew.cmu.edu.

Statement on Diversity

The topics that we're covering in this class are often difficult, not just intellectually but emotionally. While I expect there to be rigorous discussion and even disagreement in the course of our class discussions, I ask that you engage in discussion with care and empathy for the other members in the classroom. Aim to disagree without becoming disagreeable. In this class we will not shy away from the uncomfortable. Critically examining and assessing our most basic assumptions and values is not just one of the tasks of philosophy but is an activity vital to living an authentic life. I urge you to have the courage to the uncomfortable in this class. In exchange for your courage, I will work to ensure a classroom environment that supports your taking these intellectual and emotional risks.

Furthermore, all people have the right to be addressed and referred to in accordance with their personal identity. In this class, we will have the chance to indicate the name that we prefer to be called and, if we choose, to identify pronouns with which we would like to be addressed. I will do my best to address and refer to all students accordingly and support classmates in doing so as well.

Inclusive, Reader-Oriented Language Choices

In this class, we take a reader-oriented view of language and standards, and I encourage you to make decisions about your written language choices according to how your reader may respond. This view means that we use language to connect with a community of readers and that we do not use language that might alienate anybody in that community. In other words, we use language to create particular effects for our readers. If we want to communicate professionalism, we use a style guide for our academic writing. If

we want to communicate that we are writing with precision, we use conventions such as appropriate verb tenses. To that end, I encourage you to use language that does not exclude or alienate readers. For example, consider the latest conventions for referring to race and class that do not mark difference or communicate to our readers that they are somehow "other." Another example for writing inclusively is to use non-binary gendered pronouns. The emerging convention for using gendered pronouns is that we should consider writing in a style that includes both the feminine and masculine, using a gender-neutral plural form (*they*) in place of binary pronouns like he/she. The National Council of Teachers in English (NCTE) gives us some examples on their website http://www.ncte.org/positions/statements/genderfairuseoflang. Whenever possible, we aim to use our language to build connections with our audience. Using inclusive language can help us make that connection. (Note: Language conventions are tricky and situated. In other words, reason about them. Don't apply language formulas.)

Student Academic Success & Communication Support

During the semester (and across your undergraduate years), you may find that you would like to pursue extra support for your writing. You can find support for your academic work and for your writing and communication skills in the following ways:

- Make a 1:1 virtual appointment with a writing tutor through the Communication Support Team at Student Academic Success
- Attend writing skills workshops offered by Communication Support
- Seek language support or find a Study Partner offered through Student Academic Success

You can find these and other services by going to the Student Academic Success website: https://www.cmu.edu/student-success/

Guidelines for Self-Care: First Things First

This semester should be challenging, engaging, and fruitful. Make choices so that you can act with resilience as you face the unfolding demands and expectations of college life. Being resilient means that you can bounce back from setbacks and disappointments and that you can take on somewhat intimidating tasks. **Resilient people make sure that they get sleep, eat a variety of foods, stay connected with friends, and get some physical exercise.**

However, don't be embarrassed if you're having trouble keeping "first things first." Ask for help. All of us benefit from support during times of struggle. You are not alone. There are many helpful resources available on campus, and an important part of the college experience is learning how to ask for help. Remember the message you heard during orientation week: *It is a sign of strength to ask for help.*

If you or anyone you know experiences any academic stress, difficult life events, or feelings like anxiety or depression, I strongly encourage you to seek support. Counseling and Psychological Services (CaPS) is here to help: call 412-268-2922 and visit their website at http://www.cmu.edu/counseling/. Consider reaching out to a friend, faculty or family member you trust for help getting connected to the support that can help. You can feel free to talk to me at any time, and I'll do my best to get you the support you need.

Grading Criteria for all Minor Writing Assignments (unless otherwise specified)

Well Done Work Full points (5/5 or 10/10)	Fair Work 8/9 or 4 points	Needs a lot of Work 7 or below/3 or below
The assignment criteria have been met thoughtfully and with insight. The analysis is planned and articulated with convincing detail**;** questions are thoroughly answered.	The assignment criteria have been met with some evidence of effort and thought in this assignment. However, responses may be cursory, lacking necessary connections, or lack key aspects of the assignment.	The assignment criteria may have been met, but these assignments do not move beyond broad generalizations. The work is hard to read, incomplete, or presented poorly.

Papers such as the CRA and TLA will be assessed according to a rubric that gauges how well the student has met the requirements of the assignment and achieved the course objectives in that writing assignment. Rubrics are available on Canvas on the assignment page, but are subject to change.

Course Calendar

Fall 2023 · Women in Science Fiction

76-106 / *First Mini* / *Monday-Wednesday-Friday*

Class date	Class focus	Readings / class preparation
Mon, Aug 28	Introduction to women's speculative fiction and early modern imagination.	Margaret Cavendish, *The Blazing World* (1666), opening sections.
Wed, Aug 30	Travel, discovery, narrative perspective, and other worlds.	Cavendish, *The Blazing World*, opening journey and arrival.
Fri, Sep 1	World-building, knowledge, and intellectual history.	Cavendish, *The Blazing World*, passages on learning and invention.
Wed, Sep 6	Gender, sovereignty, and the imagined Empress.	Cavendish, *The Blazing World*, passages on imperial rule.
Fri, Sep 8	Close reading and discussion of interpretive claims.	Finish Cavendish, *The Blazing World*.
Mon, Sep 11	Narrative frames and women's representations of science.	Mary Shelley, *Frankenstein* (1818), Volume I.
Wed, Sep 13	Creation, scientific ambition, and the limits of knowledge.	Shelley, *Frankenstein*, Volume I.
Fri, Sep 15	Education, voice, and the creature's exclusion.	Shelley, *Frankenstein*, Volume II.
Mon, Sep 18	Ethics of knowledge and competing perspectives.	Shelley, *Frankenstein*, Volumes II–III.
Wed, Sep 20	Responsibility, consequences, and close-reading workshop.	Finish Shelley, *Frankenstein*, Volume III.

Course Calendar / continued

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76-106 / *First Mini* / *Monday-Wednesday-Friday*

Class date	Class focus	Readings / class preparation
Fri, Sep 22	Utopian narration and gendered assumptions.	Charlotte Perkins Gilman, *Herland* (1915), chapters 1–2.
Mon, Sep 25	Feminist utopia, social critique, and world-building.	Gilman, *Herland*, chapters 3–4.
Wed, Sep 27	Institutions, social organization, and gender.	Gilman, *Herland*, chapters 5–6.
Fri, Sep 29	Alien encounters, genre expectations, and representation.	C. L. Moore, “Shambleau” (1933).
Mon, Oct 2	Desire, monstrosity, and character agency.	Revisit key passages from Moore, “Shambleau.”
Wed, Oct 4	Narrative perspective, invisibility, and gender.	James Tiptree Jr., “The Women Men Don’t See” (1973).
Fri, Oct 6	Gender, estrangement, and reader expectations.	Revisit key passages from “The Women Men Don’t See.”
Mon, Oct 9	Embodiment, consent, kinship, and power.	Octavia E. Butler, “Bloodchild” (1984).
Wed, Oct 11	Race, gender, and the speculative future.	Revisit key passages from Butler, “Bloodchild.”
Fri, Oct 13	Synthesis: women’s speculative writing from Cavendish to Butler.	Review selected passages from the course readings.